Gilgit. On 30 October 1947, he proposed this to Ghansara Singh saying that the alternative option was for him to hold a referendum in the Gilgit Agency. This would be along the lines of the referendum suggested by Mountbatten for the entire state. That way, Ghansara Singh could continue to govern the province till the requisite authority took over. Singh disagreed as both these options not only offended his Dogra pride but also counted as acts of treason against the Maharaja. As a result, Brown had no choice but to put into execution Operation Datta Khel on the night of 31 October 1947.

Brown laid siege to the Governor's residence that night and after a fierce gun battle, Ghansara Singh and his staff were outnumbered and forced to surrender. The next morning, on 1 November 1947, Brown sent cipher messages by radio to Abdul Qayyum Khan and Col. Bacon informing them that he was now *pro tem* administrator of Gilgit. Brown's message to Abdul Qayyum Khan was carefully worded and dispelled the notion that the *coup d'*état had been performed at the instigation of the British Government. Now that power had passed to Brown, it had to be held and preserved until it could be passed on to the Government of Pakistan and permanently secured in their favour. Further, plans had to be implemented on how to keep the Indian Army at bay.

Maj. Brown had no remorse. He had committed treason against the state of Jammu and Kashmir after taking an oath to uphold the state's constitution and the rule of the Maharaja. He had drawn generous pay and allowances and had confiscated a reported amount of £60,000 of the state's funds lying in the treasury at Gilgit.[18] There are unsubstantiated indications that this sum could have been much more. He had deserted, mutinied and instigated the Gilgit Scouts to mutiny, and had ordered the scouts to finish off large parts of the Maharaja's forces by deceit. Since the state of Jammu and Kashmir had acceded to and been accepted by India, which was then a dominion of the British Empire, his actions had amounted to waging war against the king and was an act of high treason. Not only Maj. William Brown, but his subordinate officer Capt. Jock Mathieson, Col. Roger Bacon, Sir George Cunningham, Gen. Sir Frank Messervy, Lord Ismay and